Nikki Nasseri

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Education

George Mason University August 2026 - May 3031
- PhD in Information Sciences and Technology

University of California-Berkeley August 2025 - May 2026
- M.A. in Learning Sciences & Human Development

University of California-Irvine September 2023 - June 2025
- B.A in Psychological Science, GPA 3.99/4.00
- Graduated Magna Cum Laude

Irvine Valley College August 2021 - May 2023
- A.A. in Psychological Science
- Cum Laude, Dean's list

Grants and Awards

- NSF GRFP Fellow (Ranked Tier 1) August 2026
- UCI School of Social Ecology Honors Program & Excellence in Research Distinction Award June 2025
- UCI UROP Research Grant, $251 December 2024
- UCI Summer Undergraduate Research Program (SURP) Research Grant, $1,500 June 2024
- UCI Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program (UROP) Publication Award, $1,000 March 2024
- UCI UROP Research Grant, $500 December 2023

Projects

Speaky Link - *Personal Project* 2026
- Built an immersive, VR-style language-learning app with 27 interactive 3D environments (React, three.js)
- Developed AI characters with memory, branching dialogue, and real-time pronunciation feedback
- Designing a user study comparing usability and learning outcomes against Duolingo (results loading...)

Benchmark Contamination in Text-to-Image Evaluation - *Personal Project* *October 2026*
- Audited whether 3,152 prompts from three text-to-image benchmarks appear in public training data
- Built a streaming Python pipeline that scanned 1.39B DataComp-1B captions and 1.83M DiffusionDB prompts on a laptop
- Found 31.5% of DrawBench prompts copied verbatim in user-prompt data vs. 2% in web captions

Conference and Academic Presentations

- Siddiqui, M. N., **Nasseri, N.,** Coscia, A., Pea, R., & Subramonyam, H. (2026, April 13-17). *DraftMarks: Enhancing Transparency in Human-AI Co-Writing Through Interactive Skeuomorphic Process Traces* [Conference Paper]. Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI). Barcelona, Spain.
- **Nasseri, N.,** He, K., & Warschauer, M. (2026, April 8-12). *Comparing Children's Verbal Engagement with an Interactive Media Character and a Human during Video Watching* [Poster & Lightning Talk Presentation]. American Educational Research Association. Los Angeles, CA, United States.
- **Nasseri, N.,** He, K., & Warschauer, M. (2026, April 8-12). *Examining Children's Scientific Misconceptions from an Educational Video with an Embedded Conversational Agent* [Poster & Lightning Talk Presentation]. American Educational Research Association. Los Angeles, CA, United States.
- **Nasseri, N.,** He, K., & Warschauer, M. (2025, August 7-9). *How AI Dialogue Clarifies Scientific Misconceptions for Children* [Poster presentation]. American Psychological Association. Denver, Colorado, United States.
- **Nasseri, N.,** He, K., & Warschauer, M. (2025, May 27). *Engaging Young Viewers: Children's Verbal Interaction with AI Characters Compared to Human* [Oral presentation]. UCI School of Social Ecology Honors Collegium. Irvine, California, United States.
- **Nasseri, N.,** He, K., & Warschauer, M. (2025, May 1-3). *Verbal Participation of Young Children with AI Conversational Agents and Human Partners* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development. Minneapolis, Minnesota, United States.

- Younies, N., Dastmalchi, N., **Nasseri, N.,** Wang, R., Luu, J., & Pressman, S. (2024, May 23-26). *Unlocking the Secrets of Vacation Bliss: Exploring the Link Between Well-Being and Vacation Activities – Insights into the Positive Influence of Social Engagement and Calming Pursuits, and the Detrimental Impact of Work-related Activities on Overall Wellness* [Poster presentation]. Association for Psychological Science. San Francisco, CA, United States.
- Dastmalchi, N., Youneis, N., **Nasseri, N.,** Wang, R., Luu, J., & Pressman, S. (2024, April 24-28). *Optimizing Recreation: The Relationship Between Different Types of Vacation Activities and Overall Well-Being* [Poster presentation]. The Western Psychological Association. San Francisco, CA, United States.

Manuscripts Under Review & In Preparation

- Tajik, E., Shahrokhian, B., Borchers, C., Sankaranarayanan, S., Jin, H., **Nasseri, N.,** Moore, S. J., Jiang, Z., Feyzi Behnagh, R., & Shi, Y. (2027). *Thought Partner or Prescriptor? Exploring K-12 Teachers' Perceptions of AI-Generated Classroom Reflections via "Reasoning" Traces* [Submitted]. Proceedings of the 2027 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems.
- Tajik, E., Shahrokhian, B., Sankaranarayanan, S., Jin, H., **Nasseri, N.,** Moore, S. J., Jiang, Z., Feyzi Behnagh, R., Shi, Y., Maldonado, R., & Borchers, C. (2027). *Designing for Disagreement: Teacher Sensemaking of Competing AI Interpretations of Learning Analytics Dashboards* [Submitted]. Proceedings of the 2027 International Learning Analytics and Knowledge Conference (LAK '27).
- **Nasseri, N.,** Subramonyam, H., Pea, R., Seifert, C., & Gerstenberg, T. (2025). *Learning by Creating: Investigating Interactive Simulation Building as a Tool for Deeper Understanding* [Manuscript in preparation]. *Journal of Educational Technology.*
- Siddiqui, M. N., **Nasseri, N.,** Coscia, A., Pea, R., & Subramonyam, H. (2025, September 27). *DraftMarks: Enhancing transparency in human-AI co-writing through interactive skeuomorphic process traces.* arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2509.23505

Research Internships

Stanford HAI Institute - *Research Intern* June 2025 - June 2026

PI: Hariharan Subramonyam

- Project: *Learning by Creating*
  - Led the Learning by Creating project, studying how participants learn through building simulations versus reading texts
  - Designed and obtained IRB approval, recruited participants, and managed study logistics
  - Built a full-stack interactive simulation platform from scratch using React, nodes.js and JavaScript, saving entries and managing versions with Git
  - Deployed app via Heroku
  - Created pre-tests, post-tests, and a post-study survey from scratch to measure learning outcomes and engagement

Independent Research Projects

Children's Verbal Engagement with AI Agents vs. Humans Digital Learning Lab, UCI

Honors Thesis Recipient September 2024 - June 2025

- Conducting an honors thesis under Dr. Mark Warschauer on children's verbal engagement with an AI-powered interactive character versus a human during video watching
- Developed metrics to analyze children's verbal engagement, including their response rate, length, accuracy, relevance, and intelligibility
- Preformed regression analysis to compare children's response to an AI agent versus a human co-viewer, controlling their baseline language proficiency and science knowledge
- Disseminated findings to the SRCD conference and the UROP symposium in 2025

The Relationship between Vacation and Well-being Stress, Emotion, & Physical Health Lab, UCI

Grant Recipient June 2024 - May 2025

- As a first author on UROP poster investigated the relationship between how different types of leisure activities during vacations impact subjective well-being
- Conducted Pearson correlation and multiple regression analyses to examine the relationship between vacation activities and well-being outcomes such as stress, happiness, and sleep quality

- Analyzed self-reported sleep quality and Fitbit sleep data to explore the relationship between vacation activities and sleep quality
- Presented findings at the UCI UROP Symposium in 2024

Children's Scientific Misconceptions from Educational Media Digital Learning Lab, UCI
Independent Undergraduate Researcher July 2024 - December 2024

- Developed a coding scheme of five categories of misconceptions through a literature review
- Analyzed children's responses to post-test assessments in R to identify and calculate the percentage distribution of each scientific misconception category
- Provided design implications for more effective science television shows to improve educational outcomes
- Disseminate future directions for media developers to design educational content that minimizes misconceptions in children's media.
- Introduce the idea of integrating AI conversational agents to media developers to enhance learning experiences in children's programming.

Undergraduate Research Experience

Digital Learning Lab - *Research Assistant* February 2024 - June 2025

PI: Mark Warschauer

- Project: *Converse to Learn*
    - Developed scoring rubrics and scored children's response to post-test assessments to evaluate their learning from science narrative videos
    - Analyzed scoring discrepancies among team members using Excel, fostering discussions to achieve consensus on children's responses
    - Examined AI agents' performance by comparing how AI agents and human researchers classify children's responses
    - Transcribed children's verbal engagement during interactions with a human co-viewer, categorizing responses to ensure consistent analysis of engagement with different learning agents

Stress, Emotion & Physical Health Lab - *Research Assistant* June 2023 - June 2025

PI: Sarah Pressman

- Project: *Wearable Technologies to Assess Physiology, Emotions & Reward Seeking Behaviors*
    - Developed and refined study procedure scripts, materials, and training guides to standardize research practices.
    - Trained and mentored new undergraduate research assistants on lab protocols and procedures.
    - Edited and designed psychological surveys to ensure clarity and accuracy in data collection.
    - Conducted study sessions involving stress-inducing experimental procedures for data collection.
    - Implemented ecological momentary assessment (EMA) procedures to evaluate daily behaviors.
- Project: *Stress, Emotion and Energy (SEE) Facial Coding*
    - Transcribe and organize data from Noldus Facereader software into structured Excel spreadsheets, ensuring data accuracy and consistency
    - Analyze, clean, and organize HRV and impedance data through Excel software functions
    - Contribute to the development of research ideas and insights based on data collected
    - Disseminated research findings and insights to project leaders and team members
- Project: *SEE COVID Facial Coding*
    - Convert participants ZOOM interview to Noldus Facereader to properly code facial expressions
    - Transfer coded facial expression data to excel spreadsheet and initiate data coding and cleaning
    - Communicated project progress and research findings to project managers and team members

Teaching Experience

Psychology Honors Thesis Seminar - *Graduate Student Tutor* August 2025 - Present

- Held weekly office hours for a class of 20 students, providing one-on-one guidance on all aspects of their honors thesis projects
- Assisted with research design, literature reviews, data analysis, and interpretation of results

- Reviewed and provided feedback on writing, including drafts, APA formatting, and results presentation
- Advised students on research ethics, study planning, and milestone management to ensure timely thesis completion

Positive Psychology - *Learning Assistant* January 2025 - Mar 2025

- Organized virtual office hours for individual student consultations regarding course material or academic support needs, with my knowledge in the psychology course
- Deliver feedback using positive reinforcement techniques to encourage, motivate and build confidence in students.
- Responded promptly to student emails, assisting with course material and assignments while collaborating with the professor to address concerns and answer questions
- Facilitate discussion boards among students to encourage collaboration, critical thinking, and problem solving skills

Media & Public Engagement

Featured Guest- *UCI UROP Researcher Roundup Podcast* May 2025

- **Episode:** "Fake News!" –Discussed the research process as a UCI undergraduate by designing a hypothetical study to test a satirical scientific claim and reflecting on how research works
- Selected to represent UCI's undergraduate research community and promote research accessibility for diverse audiences
- Shared experiences as a student researcher and encouraged research engagement through science communication

Skills

- **Statistical analysis:** T-tests, chi-squared, ANOVA, linear and multiple regression, correlation, factor analysis (R, SPSS, JASP, Excel)
- **Qualitative methods:** structured and semi-structured interviews, thematic analysis
- **Programming & tools:** Python, R, Jupyter Notebook, Git, VS Code
- **Familiar with:** JavaScript, React, AI-assisted prototyping and deployment
- **Languages:** Farsi (native), English (native), Spanish (intermediate), Russian (beginner)